Effects of acid rain

When fossil fuels are burned in power stations and factories, sulfur dioxide (SO_2) and nitrogen oxides spew out of their chimneys. Spreading through the lower atmosphere, these gases react with water to produce dilute sulfuric acid (H_2SO_4) and nitric acid (HNO_3). These weak acids fall as rain and enter rivers and lakes, making them more acidic. Increased acidity stresses animals and plants. Water snails disappear, fish eggs fail to hatch, and insects and the frogs that eat them die. Eventually, lakes will not support any life.

By the early 1970s, thousands of lakes in Scandinavia had lost their fish and were virtually dead. By 1984, Brooktrout Lake and others in the Adirondack Mountains, New York, were devoid of fish. Acid rain also leaches harmful aluminum from the soil, and acidic clouds and fog harm plants, reducing their ability to photosynthesize, leading to death.

